Graduate Student Position Announcement - Utah State University – Spring 2026

Position title: Ph.D. Graduate Research Assistantship (GRA), Mountains as disease refugia for moose in a changing world

Position description: The GRA will study how animals can use spatial refugia, behavioral adaptations, and/or movement-related strategies to adapt to warming climates and increased parasite exposure. Research will focus on moose and their parasites (winter ticks, arterial worms) in the Wasatch Mountains, Utah. Key aims include: 1) assessing how climate and parasites impact moose dispersal, movement, and habitat selection; 2) understanding how adaptive strategies in movement can affect moose reproduction, survival, and population persistence; and 3) developing future projections of how moose spatial distributions will change in response to climate and parasites.

The GRA will conduct field work to monitor moose with GPS radio-collars to understand movement and demography in relation to parasite loads. They will monitor moose movement using ground-based surveys and conduct field examinations of moose mortalities to determine cause of death. In addition, the GRA will build advanced habitat selection, movement, and population models of moose in response to changing climate conditions and parasite numbers to help inform moose management in Utah. Research will be conducted in collaboration with agency scientists and managers at the Utah Division of Wildlife Resources, and another GRA studying moose-parasite interactions.

Supervisors: Dr. T.J. Clark-Wolf, Department of Wildland Resources and Ecology Center; Dr. Sara Weinstein, Department of Biology, Utah State University

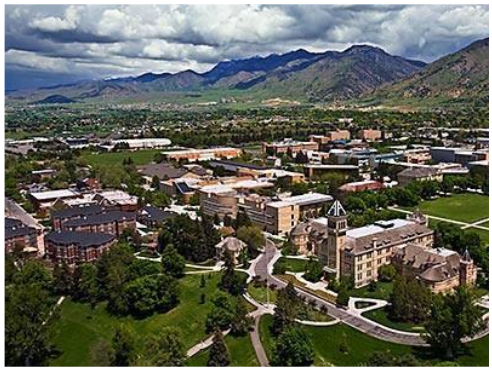
Stipend/Salary: $30K plus benefits and tuition/fees waiver

Start date: January 2026 preferred

Minimum qualifications:
1. MS in wildlife biology, biology, ecology or related field
2. Experience conducting field research
3. Proficiency in R or other programming languages
4. Excellent written and personal communication skills
5. Ability to work both independently and collaboratively with agency scientists and wildlife technicians
6. Experience analyzing, presenting, and publishing scientific results

Desired qualifications:
1. Background in statistical/mathematical techniques in ecology/biology
2. Experience monitoring animal movement and investigating mortality, as well as strong teamwork skills in the field

How to Apply: Please submit a *single PDF* to t.j.clark-wolf@usu.edu titled "GRAPosition_Moose_ApplicantLastName_ApplicantFirstName". This PDF should include:
1. A one-page cover letter that describes your motivations, qualifications and how this position advances your career goals.
2. A CV/resume that includes contact information (phone and email) for at least two references.
3. Unofficial transcripts from undergraduate and (if applicable) graduate education.
4. Scientific writing sample (academic paper or report written primarily by the applicant).

We will begin reviewing applications on Sept 8th, 2025 and the position will remain open until filled.

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